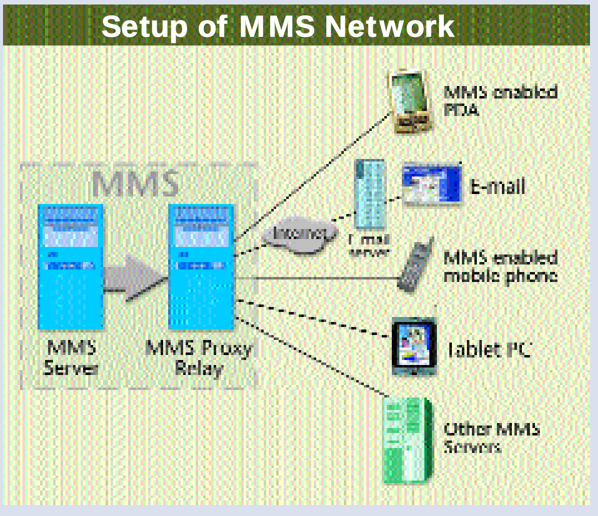
Connecting People

In order to implement MMS, it needs to be enabled on the side of the service provider as well as the user. When you send an MMS, it is sent through the existing cellular connectivity standard the user is using, which could be GPRS (which is 2.5G) or a newer 3G standard like UMTS. On receiving the message, the Multi Media Service Centre (MMSC) sends the sender a confirmation that the message is received. The MMSC then sends the receiver a notification that a new message is waiting. Since MMS messages are larger than SMS messages, service providers have introduced an option where the user can choose to download the message immediately or download it later.

On downloading the message, the receiver gets an acknowledgement from the MMSC that the message is successfully downloaded. Once the receiver has successfully downloaded the message, a confirmation is sent by the MMSC to the receiver—somewhat like what happens when you download a file from the Internet.

On the side of the network operator, the user's MMS handset (the MMS client) talks to a central MMS server. This is the core component that handles the technology behind the MMS service where messages are stored and transmission protocols are implemented. This server works in tandem (and is sometimes even integrated into) an MMS Proxy-Relay. The Proxy-Relay is the intermediary between the user and the MMS server. It works to grant access to the messaging and storage services, which could be as varied as cellular phones, tablet PCs, PDAs, etc. It also provides access to the messaging services on other messaging systems such as e-mail, SMS and paging.



scribbles and doodles to other handsets that support MMS.

The fun doesn't stop with just making and sharing movies, audio and picture clips. MMS is just the beginning of a whole slew of services. In its present form, 2.5G networks let you access the Net on a mobile device at between 20-70 Kbps (the theoretical speed is 144 Kbps), equivalent to a regular modem/phone line access. An average MMS is 5 to 15 KB in size. Hence, most new MMS-compliant devices have at least 30 KB of memory to suport them.

When 3G, the next level, finally turns up, you could experience speeds anywhere from 144 Kbps right up to 384 Kbps. Your MMS messages would then take on the form of high-quality streaming video and audio. Services like these are already being seen in the new 3G networks in Japan and South Korea.

The gear

To use and enjoy this multimedia-rich service over a mobile device, you need an MMS-enabled mobile device or an MMS-enabled PDA (*see box, 'Phones that Make you Go Mmmm!'*). Though older handsets that do not have support for MMS will not be able to use this services, already mobile phones are getting smarter. Phones now offer PDA like functionality (the Sony Ericsson P800 comes very close to doing just that) and yes, they are meant for more than punching numbers and exchanging messages. They don't talk back (yet!) but the newer phones are more than just phones. With Java enabled functionality, you can actually download and play games, whenever and wherever you want and create richer MMS messages.

Mobile phone manufacturers are making newer phones into colourful, fun devices. There are going to be quite a few technological innovations in the near future as manufacturers scramble to integrate more into a phone. The Sony Ericsson T68i, for example, has built-in support for POP3 e-mail. The T68i as well as the upcoming Sony Ericsson P800 and the Nokia 7650 all feature cameras.